Talking Steps Guide

Talking Steps

Talking steps are the communication skills most children develop around certain ages. They are the small steps that show how your child's communication and understanding are growing.

Every child develops at their own pace, but these steps help parents and doctors know whether a child's speech and language skills are on track or if they may need a communication boost.

Talking Steps	Timeline
Cooing (e.g., Ooohh, Ahhhh)	Birth- 3 Months
Babbling (e.g., consonants will increase such as daaaa to dadadada)	4 to 9 Months
Single Words	10 months-18 months

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How to move to the next stage	Examples
Cooing	Once your baby coos, gently expand it. • "ooo" → "ooo ba" • "ah" → "ah ah ah" This models how sounds can be repeated and combined, which leads to babbling.
Babbling	When your child babbles, look at them and respond. Talk back to them in an excited tone. Try copying the little noises they make or taking turns making simple sounds to show them you are listening.
Single Words	Children learn words through repetition. Short, frequent practice works best, so try to highlight one target word many times throughout the day. You can still use other words, just gently repeat the target word often in natural, loving moments. Example: Wow, I can see that you want more cheese! More cheese. Mya wants more, more, more, cheese. More cheese for Mya. (That's already 6 repetitions in 30 seconds!) Note: Pause before repeating a line to give your child a chance to vocalize. Even a smile or sound attempt counts.

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Risks and alternatives

Some common habits can slow your child's speech development, so here are simple alternatives that encourage stronger communication.

Avoid these	Replace with these
Asking your child to "say it" before giving them what they want.	Model the word yourself. For example, say "milk" three times and then hand it to them. This teaches them without pressure.
Talking too fast or using long sentences.	Slow down and use short, simple phrases like "big ball" or "want more?" so your child can understand and imitate.
Ignoring or missing their communication attempts	Babies use many nonverbal ways to communicate, such as eye contact, body movements, giggles, and smiles. Treat these moments as meaningful communication and respond as if they used words by engaging in a back and forth interaction (for example, "I see that too" or "I like that").

Looking for simple ways to support your toddler's speech growth?

You can take a deep breath. In this free speech boost session, you will learn practical steps you can use in everyday moments to encourage your toddler to start using more words.

Let's Connect

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For any questions, please email us:

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Disclaimer: This guide does not replace an evaluation by a licensed speech-language pathologist. If you are concerned about your child's speech and language development, book a speech evaluation with us in the DFW area or consult with your pediatrician for a referral in your area.